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Robert Rivas, a Democrat with Rural Roots, Becomes Powerful California Assembly Speaker

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It was a day that seemed like it might not ever happen: Robert Rivas was sworn in Friday as the next speaker of the California Assembly.

The ascension of the Salinas Democrat to lead the lower chamber of the Legislature brings to a definitive close a dramatic power struggle that bitterly divided the majority caucus of the Assembly last summer and fall.

"We must work with urgency and unity — unity that is backed by mutual trust and respect," Rivas said during a speech in the Assembly chambers of the state Capitol attended by top California political figures, including Gov. Gavin Newsom and former House Speaker Nancy Pelosi. "This approach will allow us to make measurable progress on the most critical issues facing Californians. It will show the rest of the country that progressive government works."

Internal changes that shake up how the state Capitol operates, such as rewarding close allies with powerful leadership roles and committee posts, are coming as soon as next week. What Rivas' tenure will mean for the average Californian is less certain.

Rivas has a similar ideological profile to his longtime predecessor — the outgoing Speaker Anthony Rendon, a progressive Democrat from Lakewood — so supporters do not expect a dramatic shift in the priorities of Assembly Democrats. The role is often far more about member management than policy anyway.

But supporters point to his promise, as he cobbled together votes last year from a diverse coalition of members, to establish an inclusive decision-making process, which they hope will lead to a more coherent and intentional legislative agenda.

"I'm expecting to see progress bringing the caucus together to address the most long-standing and significant policy issues facing California," such as housing and climate change, said Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel, a Woodland Hills Democrat.

Rivas could also potentially ring in an era of closer collaboration with Newsom, who has clashed at times with lawmakers as he has increasingly sought to pursue his ambitious agenda through the Legislature.

At an event Thursday, Newsom expressed excitement about working with Rivas, whom he noted was an early endorser of his as Newsom launched his campaign for governor before winning his first term in 2018.

"I have a bias for him. He was there for me early, when I first ran for governor, when others didn't want to jump in the primary," Newsom said. "I'm a big fan of the incoming speaker. So I feel blessed, because it's not always the case."

A Long Transfer of Power

Rivas first made his move on the speakership more than a year ago, prompting a messy six-hour standoff in a closed-door caucus meeting that concluded with Rendon still in charge.

That might have marked the end for Rivas' aspirations, but he continued to aggressively cultivate support in the lead-up to the November election, particularly among new candidates running for their first term in the Assembly. He set up his own fundraising operation to support their campaigns, which effectively served as a rival to the

California Democratic Party's efforts, irking Rendon and his allies.

Rivas was also boosted by Govern For California, a donor network pushing the boundaries of state campaign finance law, whose political advisers include his brother.

After another six-hour meeting with the newly-elected Assembly Democratic caucus in November, Rivas emerged with an agreement to finally take over as speaker on June 30 — though even that didn't entirely calm potential challengers during the lengthy transition period.

Raised in farmworker housing on the rural Central Coast by his single mother and grandparents, Rivas will add a fresh outlook to a role that is traditionally held by members from the urban corridors of power in Los Angeles or the Bay Area, according to his supporters. They frequently point to his rise as an illustration of the California dream.

"Each of us brings to the floor different lived experiences and perspectives," said Assemblymember Rebecca Bauer-Kahan, an Orinda Democrat.

That could benefit agricultural communities and other groups who are not generally the central focus of policy-making in Sacramento.

Assemblymember Buffy Wicks, an Oakland Democrat, said that because of his upbringing, Rivas is sensitive to the needs of people who don't have a lobbyist advocating for them at the Capitol and he will fight for them.

"He's an incredibly kind, thoughtful leader," Wicks said. "And in politics, that's not always a given, is it?"

Rivas and his allies heavily emphasized his rags-to-riches biography and rural roots in their remarks at today's swearing-in ceremony, which also made time for a performance from an all-female mariachi band and recognitions of farmworkers and civil rights icon Dolores Huerta.

But it was a brief call during Rivas' speech for members to focus "less on how many bills we can pass and more on the impact we are having" that drew attention.

Speaking to reporters after the ceremony, Rivas said he did not plan to institute new limits on the number of bills — there are thousands each session — that lawmakers can introduce. But he did suggest that, as someone who "thrives off structure," he would aim to facilitate priorities and develop annual goals for the Assembly Democratic caucus in a way that might not have been possible before voters extended legislative term limits a decade ago.

"Something could be said about the forward-looking nature of members serving at that time, always trying to position themselves for what was next," Rivas said. "We have a little bit more time here with the longer term limits, so I think it's very important for us to also look in the rearview mirror. There are a lot of laws that maybe we can improve."

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